BEYOND THE ROLE

A Relational Patterns Workbook

Pattern → Purpose → Price → Possibility

A completed reflective workbook for noticing patterns,

understanding their purpose, and recovering choice.

Most of us learn ways of being in relationships long before we have words for them. We may become the capable one, the peacemaker, the person who keeps control, the one who needs very little, or the person who changes the atmosphere when things become uncomfortable. In this workbook, the word role refers to these repeated relational strategies — the ways we learned to respond to other people, especially when connection felt uncertain, demanding or emotionally charged.

You are not about to be sorted into a type. You are going to look at the patterns you reach for, understand what they may once have protected, notice what they cost you now, and practise creating more choice. The journey moves from understanding the system, to observing yourself within it, to recognising familiar patterns, mapping where they appear, and experimenting with ways of relating that are more deliberate and more aligned with your values.

The aim is not to discover which role you are.
It is to notice which strategies you reach for — and to create more choice.

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How to use this workbook

Move slowly. You do not need to complete it in order. Mark what resonates, cross out what does not, and leave questions unanswered when you are not ready. The purpose is observation, not self-diagnosis.

PART I — UNDERSTANDING THE SYSTEM

Before trying to change a pattern, it helps to understand why it may have developed. This part introduces a simple idea that will run through the whole workbook: many relational habits began as adaptations. We will look first at the family system around you, then at the purpose a familiar response may have served, before asking what possibilities are available now.

1. Families adapt

Families are systems: when one part of the system is under strain, other people adjust. In homes shaped by chronic conflict, illness, loss, addiction, emotional unpredictability, excessive responsibility, financial strain, absence, fear, or other prolonged pressures, family members may develop reliable ways of keeping life moving.

Some become exceptionally capable. Some become quiet. Some monitor everyone's mood. Some create humour. Some challenge, control, rescue, appease, achieve or disappear. These strategies may reduce distress in the short term. The problem comes when a strategy that was once useful becomes compulsory.

Core principle

A pattern is something you learned to do. It is not the whole of who you are.

What the research can — and cannot — tell us

Popular family-role models such as the Hero, Lost Child, Mascot, Scapegoat and Enabler grew largely from clinical work with families affected by alcohol dependence. They can be useful metaphors, but research has not established them as distinct, exhaustive personality categories. This means that none of us is bound by a type or a fixed way of being. An evidence-based review found conflicting support and substantial difficulty operationalising these roles. This workbook therefore uses roles as prompts for reflection, not diagnoses.

There is stronger evidence for the broader proposition that childhood adversity and the quality of family relationships matter. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), the United States' national public-health agency, identifies safe, stable and nurturing relationships and environments as important protective factors for children. Family-systems research also offers a useful way of understanding how people adapt within relationships: not simply as isolated individuals, but as people responding to patterns of closeness, tension, responsibility and stress.

Research anchors: Vernig (2011); CDC (2024–2026); Calatrava et al. (2022). Full references appear at the end.

2. Adaptation is not pathology

Before asking what a pattern costs, ask what it accomplished. A child who becomes highly responsible may have created predictability. A child who disappears may have reduced demand on an overwhelmed household. A person who becomes funny may have learned to lower tension. A caretaker may have protected relationships that felt fragile.

The goal is not to shame the old strategy. It is to recognise when it is no longer the only strategy available.

When your family was under strain, what seemed to help keep things functioning?

What did you learn made you safer, more acceptable, more useful, or less likely to create difficulty?

3. Pattern → Purpose → Price → Possibility

This framework gives you a way to follow a familiar response from automatic reaction to deliberate choice. Begin by noticing the pattern itself. Then look back with compassion at the purpose it may once have served. Notice the price of relying on it automatically now. From there, consider what becomes possible when you are no longer limited to that response — and choose one small practice that helps you rehearse the alternative. The aim is not to erase the old strategy, but to understand it well enough that it becomes a choice rather than a requirement.

PATTERN	What do I repeatedly do when relationships feel uncertain, tense or demanding?
PURPOSE	What did this response protect, preserve, prevent or provide?
PRICE	What does it cost me now — emotionally, relationally, physically or practically?
POSSIBILITY	What other response is available to the adult I am now?
PRACTICE	What small behaviour would let me rehearse that new possibility?

Choose one familiar reaction. Work through Pattern → Purpose → Price → Possibility in your own words.

PART II — THE OBSERVER POSITION

A useful way to think about the work ahead is as movement across time: understanding past patterns, observing present behaviour, and pacing future change. Looking backwards helps you understand why a strategy developed. Observing the present helps you notice when it is operating now. Looking forwards allows change to happen in small, tolerable steps rather than as a demand to become a different person overnight.

Part I asked you to look backwards with compassion: What did this pattern do for me? This part asks a different question: Can I notice the pattern while it is happening? That shift matters. A strategy has more power when it feels identical to you — "this is just who I am" — and less power when you can recognise it as one familiar response among several.

Insight alone does not necessarily change a relational pattern. The useful moment is often the few seconds in which you notice the old response beginning and create enough space to choose what happens next.

4. From role to observer

The Observer

The Observer is not detached, cold or passive. It is the part of you that can notice an emotional pattern without immediately embodying it.

This idea overlaps with several established psychological traditions. Bowen's concept of differentiation describes the capacity to remain emotionally connected to other people while retaining a clearer sense of your own thoughts, feelings and choices under relational pressure. A 2022 scoping review of 295 primary studies found substantial associations between greater differentiation of self and psychological health and marital quality, while also noting important gaps in longitudinal and causal evidence. For the reader, the practical point is not that you should become detached or unaffected. It is that closeness does not have to require losing your position, absorbing another person's emotion, or automatically performing your familiar role.

It also overlaps with psychological flexibility: the capacity to make room for thoughts, feelings and bodily discomfort while choosing behaviour that serves what matters to you. Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT) is one therapeutic approach built around this idea. A 2024 systematic and meta-analytic review found that ACT interventions improved psychological flexibility and reduced inflexibility, and that these changes were associated with reductions in psychological distress. In everyday terms, flexibility means that guilt does not have to make you rescue, anxiety does not have to make you control, and fear of disapproval does not have to make you disappear. You can notice the feeling and still choose your response.

This is why the Observer matters in this workbook. The aim is to create enough separation between you and the old pattern to recover choice. Instead of asking only, "What do I usually do here?", you begin to ask, "What is this situation actually asking of me now?"

Research anchors: Calatrava et al. (2022); Macri & Rogge (2024).

Values: what guides you when the role does not?

If you loosen an old role, you need something other than fear, guilt or habit to guide the next step. This is where values become useful. A value is not a rule you must perform perfectly and it is not a goal you can complete. It is a quality you want your behaviour to express — for example honesty, care, courage, fairness, dignity, patience, respect, responsibility, faithfulness or self-respect.

The distinction is important: a role often says, "What must I do so that I stay safe, useful, accepted or in control?" A values-based question asks, "Who do I want to be that is not driven by fear or compulsion and is conscious enough to respond to what is actually happening?" The same value can produce different

behaviour in different situations. Care might mean helping someone today and declining to take over for them tomorrow. Honesty might mean speaking clearly rather than arguing until you are understood. Self-respect might mean leaving a conversation and returning when it is calmer.

Values are especially useful in the pause between an old urge and a new response. Imagine that someone you love is upset with you. Your familiar role might tell you to fix the feeling, defend yourself, give in, withdraw, or force agreement. A value gives you a different compass. If you choose care and self-respect, for example, you might listen without taking over, speak honestly without attacking, and allow the other person to remain disappointed. The question is not, 'How do I make this discomfort disappear?' but, 'How do I want to behave while this discomfort is here?'

Try choosing three to five values that you would like to recognise in the way you relate to people. You do not need perfect words. Ask: When I am not being driven by fear or an old role, what qualities do I want to bring into my relationships?

My values might include: _____

_____

Later, when the workbook asks, "Who do I want to be in this moment?", it is inviting you back here. You are not being asked to invent a better personality under pressure. You are choosing the next behaviour that most closely reflects the person you want to practise being.

The Observer Pause

- 1. What is happening in me right now?
- 2. What am I feeling — beneath the first reaction?
- 3. What am I afraid might happen?
- 4. Which familiar strategy am I moving toward?
- 5. What actually belongs to me here?
- 6. What belongs to the other person?
- 7. What response fits my values now — rather than my old role?

A sentence to practise

"I notice the urge to _____. I do not have to obey the urge immediately."

Think of a recent interaction in which you reacted automatically. What might the Observer have noticed?

Once you can pause and observe your own response, you can begin to notice what happens between people. The next model is useful because relational patterns rarely occur alone: one person's move often invites a move from someone else, and positions can change quickly within the same conversation.

5. The Drama Triangle — application

Stephen Karpman's Drama Triangle is a transactional-analysis model describing movement among three positions commonly called Victim, Rescuer and Persecutor. In this workbook these words describe interactional positions, not identities and not moral verdicts.

Position	Inner pull	Typical move	Observer alternative
Powerless position	"I have no choice."	Collapse, wait, surrender agency	Name what is not controllable — then identify one available choice.
Rescuing position	"I must fix this."	Over-function, advise, take over	Stay present; ask what is wanted; offer only what is genuinely yours to give.
Blaming/controlling position	"Someone must make this right."	Criticise, pressure, dominate	Name the problem and boundary without attacking the person.

People can move rapidly between these positions. A rescuer who becomes exhausted may feel powerless; a powerless position may turn into blame; a blaming position may later attempt repair by rescuing. The useful question is not "Which one am I?" but "Where did I move, and what happened next?"

Describe one interaction in which you moved through more than one position.

What would the Observer position have allowed you to do differently?

PART III — FIVE ADAPTIVE PATTERNS IN FAMILIES

You now have two pieces of the framework: compassion for why patterns develop, and the Observer position from which to notice them. The next step is recognition. The five patterns that families follow are not personality types. They are broad clusters of strategies that people may reach for under relational stress.

Read them lightly. You may recognise yourself strongly in one, somewhat in several, or differently depending on the relationship. Look for the pattern beneath the label: what you tend to do, what it once protected, what it costs now, and what capacity you would like to keep. The purpose is not to fit yourself into a box. It is to increase the number of choices available outside it.

THE ACHIEVER

Possible organising belief

"If I perform, succeed or hold everything together, we may be safe."

Older role language that may overlap: Hero, Driver, Superior.

The gift inside the adaptation

- Competence, discipline, leadership, persistence, reliability, problem-solving.

When the gift becomes compulsory

- Rest feels undeserved or unsafe.
- Mistakes feel disproportionately threatening.
- You struggle to receive help.
- Achievement becomes the main route to worth.
- You take responsibility that belongs to other adults.

What this pattern may once have done for you

- When nobody else seemed reliable, being capable may have reduced chaos.
- Praise may have arrived most reliably when you succeeded.
- Achievement may have protected the family's image or your own sense of control.

Growth direction

Worth without constant performance.

Where do you recognise this pattern most strongly — family, work, friendship, parenting, partnership, or somewhere else?

What does this pattern help you avoid feeling, risking or needing?

What is genuinely valuable about this adaptation that you want to keep?

What is the price of using it automatically?

Small experiments

- Leave one non-essential task merely adequate.
- Ask for help before you are overwhelmed.
- Notice one thing you value about yourself that is unrelated to output.
- Practise resting before everything is finished.

Choose one experiment. What would make it small enough to practise this week?

THE CARETAKER

Possible organising belief

"If everyone else is okay, perhaps I can be okay."

Older role language that may overlap: Chief Enabler, Rescuer, over-responsible helper.

The gift inside the adaptation

- Empathy, attunement, generosity, loyalty, practical care, sensitivity to need.

When the gift becomes compulsory

- You know what everyone else needs before you know what you need.
- Another person's distress feels like an instruction.
- You give help that was not requested.
- Resentment follows over-giving.
- Boundaries feel cruel.

What this pattern may once have done for you

- Caring may have preserved connection in a fragile family.
- You may have learned that usefulness secured belonging.
- Monitoring others may once have helped you anticipate danger or conflict.

Growth direction

Care without taking ownership of another adult's life.

Where do you recognise this pattern most strongly — family, work, friendship, parenting, partnership, or somewhere else?

What does this pattern help you avoid feeling, risking or needing?

What is genuinely valuable about this adaptation that you want to keep?

What is the price of using it automatically?

Small experiments

- Ask, “Do you want listening, ideas, or practical help?”
- Wait before volunteering.
- Let a safe person experience a manageable consequence.
- Name one need without first justifying it.

Choose one experiment. What would make it small enough to practise this week?

THE CONTROLLER

Possible organising belief

"If I can make things predictable, correct or orderly, I may be safe."

Older role language that may overlap: Righter, Controller, Gooder.

The gift inside the adaptation

- Standards, discernment, organisation, decisiveness, conscientiousness, foresight.

When the gift becomes compulsory

- Uncertainty produces urgency.
- Difference feels like disobedience or danger.
- You correct when connection would serve better.
- You over-explain or argue to secure agreement.
- You struggle to let others do things differently.

What this pattern may once have done for you

- Rules may have created predictability where people did not.
- Being right may have protected you from shame or helplessness.
- Control may have been the closest available substitute for safety.

Growth direction

Influence without domination; clarity without requiring compliance.

Where do you recognise this pattern most strongly — family, work, friendship, parenting, partnership, or somewhere else?

What does this pattern help you avoid feeling, risking or needing?

What is genuinely valuable about this adaptation that you want to keep?

What is the price of using it automatically?

Small experiments

- State a preference once and allow a safe difference.
- Ask a question before correcting.
- Practise saying, “I may see this differently.”
- Identify what you can control: your action, boundary, participation and exit.

Choose one experiment. What would make it small enough to practise this week?

THE DISAPPEARING SELF

Possible organising belief

"If I need very little and stay out of the way, I may remain safe."

Older role language that may overlap: Lost Child, withdrawn/inadequate position.

The gift inside the adaptation

- Independence, imagination, observation, low drama, creativity, ability to self-entertain.

When the gift becomes compulsory

- You vanish when conflict begins.
- You minimise needs until they become urgent.
- Decisions feel difficult because preference itself feels unfamiliar.
- People experience you as distant although you care deeply.
- You confuse invisibility with peace.

What this pattern may once have done for you

- Being easy may have reduced pressure on an overwhelmed household.
- Privacy may have been safer than exposure.
- Not asking may have protected you from disappointment or rejection.

Growth direction

Presence, preference and agency.

Where do you recognise this pattern most strongly — family, work, friendship, parenting, partnership, or somewhere else?

What does this pattern help you avoid feeling, risking or needing?

What is genuinely valuable about this adaptation that you want to keep?

What is the price of using it automatically?

Small experiments

- State a small preference every day.
- Stay in one safe conversation a little longer than usual.
- Ask for something before you are desperate.
- Use the sentence: “I am here, and I have a view.”

Choose one experiment. What would make it small enough to practise this week?

THE DISRUPTOR / DISTRACTOR

Possible organising belief

"If I change the emotional atmosphere, perhaps we will not have to feel what is underneath it."

Older role language that may overlap: Mascot, Aginner, Excitement Seeker.

The gift inside the adaptation

- Humour, energy, courage, spontaneity, originality, willingness to challenge stale systems.

When the gift becomes compulsory

- Serious emotion is quickly converted into humour, argument or activity.
- Calm feels flat or uncomfortable.
- You create intensity when closeness becomes vulnerable.
- Opposition becomes an identity.
- Others react to the behaviour while the underlying need remains unseen.

What this pattern may once have done for you

- Humour may have released tension.
- Opposition may have been the only available route to individuality.
- Novelty or intensity may have interrupted fear, boredom or emotional deadness.

Growth direction

Authentic expression without needing to derail, perform or provoke.

Where do you recognise this pattern most strongly — family, work, friendship, parenting, partnership, or somewhere else?

What does this pattern help you avoid feeling, risking or needing?

What is genuinely valuable about this adaptation that you want to keep?

What is the price of using it automatically?

Small experiments

- Let a serious moment remain serious for thirty seconds longer.
- Name the feeling before making the joke.
- Disagree without escalating.
- Choose stimulation deliberately rather than automatically.

Choose one experiment. What would make it small enough to practise this week?

PART IV — MAPPING YOUR RELATIONAL SYSTEM

So far you have looked at the patterns themselves. Now we are going to look at the places they appear. You may respond very differently with a parent than with a partner, at work, or with your own children. In this section you will map those differences, look at how people in your family responded to stress, and notice any spoken or unspoken rules about closeness, responsibility, conflict and belonging. Try to begin with what you can actually remember or observe — what people did, what happened next, and what repeated — before deciding what it meant. This keeps the exercise curious rather than blaming.

6. You are allowed to be inconsistent

You may be an Achiever at work, a Caretaker with a parent, a Disappearing Self in conflict and a Controller when frightened. That is not a flaw in the model; it is precisely why fixed labels are unhelpful. Patterns are often relationship-specific and stress-sensitive.

Where do you become most competent and over-responsible?

With whom do you become most likely to rescue?

Where do you become controlling, corrective or rigid?

Where do you disappear, defer or stop knowing what you want?

Where do you use humour, argument, novelty or intensity to change the atmosphere?

7. Family map: observe before you explain

A family map is not a courtroom. Its purpose is not to decide who caused what. It is to notice repeated ways the system organised itself around stress, closeness, responsibility, conflict and vulnerability.

Rule for this exercise

Describe behaviour before assigning meaning. “X went quiet for three days after arguments” is more useful than “X was the Lost Child.”

Person / relationship	Under stress they tended to…	Others responded by…	What this stabilised	What it cost

What patterns repeated across generations, if any?

Which family rules were spoken? Which were never spoken but everybody seemed to know?

8. Connection and performance

The family map may show you what people did under stress. This section asks what those patterns may have taught you about belonging. For many people, the deepest pull beneath a role is not simply “I like being useful” or “I prefer being quiet.” It is the fear that connection itself depends on continuing to perform in a particular way.

Many relational adaptations can be understood through a painful question: What did I learn I had to do in order to remain connected?

- Be useful?
- Be easy?
- Be successful?
- Be funny?
- Be invisible?
- Be right?
- Be needed?
- Be strong?
- Never need anything?
- Keep everyone calm?

Complete: In my family, closeness seemed easiest when I was...

Complete: I feared that if I stopped doing that, then...

What relationships in your life now allow you to belong without performing?

A new possibility

Connection can include responsibility and care without requiring self-erasure, perfection, control or performance.

PART V — GROWING BEYOND THE ROLE

By now you may have a clearer picture of what you do, where it came from, where it appears, and what tends to activate it. That understanding matters, but this is the point at which the workbook turns toward practice. Growth does not mean stripping away the strengths contained in your adaptations. It means learning to use those strengths deliberately rather than compulsively — guided increasingly by present reality, boundaries and the values you identified earlier. The exercises that follow are designed to help you make that shift in small, repeatable ways.

9. Keep the capacity; loosen the compulsion

Growth does not require becoming the opposite of yourself. The Achiever does not need to become careless. The Caretaker does not need to become indifferent. The Controller does not need to become passive. The Disappearing Self does not need to become loud. The Disruptor does not need to become dull. The task is to keep the capacity while increasing choice.

Old compulsion	Capacity worth keeping	Freer expression
I must achieve.	Competence	I can strive and also rest.
I must rescue.	Care	I can care without taking over.
I must control.	Clarity	I can influence and set boundaries without requiring obedience.
I must disappear.	Sensitivity	I can be gentle and still be present.
I must disrupt.	Energy / individuality	I can be alive and honest without creating chaos.
Now add examples of your own. Think of an old compulsion you recognise, the capacity or strength inside it that you want to keep, and what a freer expression of that capacity might look like.		

10. The boundary between mine and yours

One of the places old roles become most powerful is around responsibility. Caretakers may carry too much; Controllers may try to manage outcomes that are not theirs; Achievers may compensate for everyone; Disappearing Selves may hand away too much agency. The Observer helps you sort responsibility more accurately: what can I influence, what must I own, and what belongs to another person?

A large part of differentiation is learning to distinguish participation from ownership. You can care about another person's feelings without taking responsibility for producing the feelings they want.

MINE	NOT MINE
My words and behaviour	Another adult's interpretation
My boundaries	Another adult's disappointment
My values and decisions	Their choices and consequences
Whether I participate	Making everyone agree
Repair for harm I cause	Preventing every uncomfortable feeling

What do you routinely carry that belongs partly or wholly to someone else?

What responsibility have you sometimes placed on others that belongs to you?

11. Tolerating the feeling that follows change

Changing a role can initially feel worse rather than better. A caretaker may feel guilty after saying no. An achiever may feel anxious while resting. A disappearing person may feel exposed after speaking. A controller may feel unsafe while allowing difference. These feelings do not automatically mean the new behaviour is wrong. Sometimes they are the emotional after-effects of doing something unfamiliar.

Psychological flexibility research supports practising the ability to experience difficult internal states while choosing behaviour in line with values. Self-compassion research also suggests that learning to respond to distress with support rather than harsh self-criticism can reduce distress, although the quality and strength of evidence vary across outcomes. For example, imagine that you say no to a request you would normally accept and guilt arrives immediately. The old pattern may interpret the guilt as proof that you have been selfish and push you to reverse the boundary. A more compassionate response might be: “I feel guilty because saying no is unfamiliar to me. I can care about this person and still have a limit.” Self-compassion does not decide whether the boundary is right; it helps you stay present long enough to consider it without punishing yourself back into the old role.

Research anchors: Macri & Rogge (2024); Han & Kim (2023); Neff (2023).

Three-part response

NOTICE: “Guilt is here.” • CONTEXTUALISE: “This is unfamiliar.” • CHOOSE: “What action fits my values and boundaries?”

Which feeling most often pulls you back into your old role?

What would help you tolerate that feeling for ten minutes without undoing your new boundary or choice?

12. Repair rather than perfection

You will fall into old patterns. You may rescue when you meant to listen, become controlling when frightened, disappear during conflict, over-perform to secure approval, or use humour or intensity to escape vulnerability. Sometimes nobody else will be harmed; you will simply notice that you abandoned your own intention. At other times the old strategy may contribute to tension, hurt or disconnection. The aim is not permanent emotional neutrality. It is faster recognition, less harm, more honest repair and a growing ability to return to choice.

Repair here means what you do after recognising that your behaviour has moved away from the way you wanted to show up. If another person was affected, repair may involve acknowledging the impact, taking responsibility for your part, apologising where appropriate, restating a boundary more cleanly, or asking what would help. If the lapse mainly affected you, repair may be internal: noticing without self-attack, understanding the trigger, and making the next choice differently. Repair is not the same as taking responsibility for another adult's entire emotional response, and it is not a demand to restore every relationship. In unsafe or coercive relationships, protection and distance may be more appropriate than relational repair.

A simple repair sequence

1. Name what you did. 2. Take responsibility for your part. 3. Do not over-explain. 4. Ask what repair is possible. 5. Learn from the trigger. 6. Resume — do not turn one lapse into an identity.

When you realise you have slipped into an old role, what do you usually do next?

What would a clean, non-defensive repair sound like?

13. Your personal growth plan

Bring the pieces together here. You are not writing a promise to never use the old pattern again. You are creating a working map for the moments when it appears: what activates it, what it is trying to protect, what you value, and what small alternative you want to practise.

My most familiar pattern	
The situations that activate it	
What it is trying to protect	
The gift I want to keep	
The cost I no longer want to pay	
My Observer sentence	
One new behaviour I will practise	
The support I may need	

Remember

The aim is not to become role-less in the sense of having no habits, strengths or responsibilities. The aim is to become less governed by automatic relational survival strategies.

APPENDIX A — A FOUR-WEEK PRACTICE

The main workbook is for understanding; this four-week practice is for rehearsal. Keep it deliberately small. Repetition matters more than dramatic change. The goal is to notice the old pathway sooner and make room, little by little, for a different response.

Week 1: Notice

Do not try to change anything yet. Record one moment each day when a familiar relational strategy appeared. Note the trigger, body sensation, thought, urge and action.

Notes

Week 2: Pause

Use the Observer Pause once per day. The success is the pause itself, even if you still choose the familiar response.

Notes

Week 3: Experiment

Choose one low-risk new behaviour: ask rather than rescue; state a preference; allow a safe difference; rest before completion; remain present without performing.

Notes

Week 4: Integrate

Review what happened. Which fears came true? Which did not? What felt freer? What needs more support or a smaller step?

Notes

APPENDIX B — QUICK OBSERVER SHEET

When I feel pulled into an old role...

STOP — I do not have to act immediately.

NOTICE — What is happening in my body, thoughts and emotions?

NAME — What familiar strategy is appearing?

SEPARATE — What is mine? What is theirs?

VALUES — Who do I want to be in this moment? Which of my chosen values do I want my response to express?

CHOOSE — What is the smallest response that fits those values and the reality of this situation?

REVIEW — What happened when I did not automatically perform the old role?

Situation

Old urge

Observer response

What I chose

What I learned

APPENDIX C — RESEARCH NOTES

This workbook deliberately separates evidence-supported constructs from useful but less validated clinical metaphors.

Family-role language

Role classifications developed in addiction/family-treatment traditions can help people notice patterns, but they should not be treated as validated diagnostic categories. Vernig's evidence-based review found conflicting evidence, measurement problems and limited work in diverse families. Accordingly, this workbook groups overlapping role descriptions into broad adaptive patterns and repeatedly discourages fixed identity labels.

Adversity and protective relationships

The CDC identifies safe, stable and nurturing relationships and environments as important protective factors in childhood and as central to preventing or buffering adverse childhood experiences. This supports the workbook's emphasis on safety, stability, connection and context rather than individual blame.

Differentiation of self

Bowen Family Systems Theory describes differentiation as maintaining a clearer sense of self while staying emotionally connected under relational pressure. Calatrava and colleagues' scoping review synthesised 295 primary studies and found substantial support for associations with psychological health and marital quality, while highlighting a shortage of longitudinal/causal studies and uncertainty about intervention effects.

Psychological flexibility

The Observer exercises also draw on the broader concept of psychological flexibility. Macri and Rogge's 2024 systematic and meta-analytic review of ACT mechanisms found that interventions improved flexibility/reduced inflexibility and that those changes were linked to reductions in psychological distress.

Self-compassion

The workbook avoids shaming adaptive patterns. A 2023 meta-analysis of 56 randomised controlled trials found small-to-medium immediate effects of self-compassion-focused interventions on depression, anxiety and stress, while noting high overall risk of bias and the need for stronger studies.

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A note on scope

This workbook is educational and reflective rather than diagnostic. It is not a substitute for individual mental-health assessment or treatment. Some patterns may arise in the context of trauma, abuse, coercion, addiction, neurodivergence, mental illness, poverty, disability, migration, caregiving, discrimination or other circumstances that require more specific understanding than a role framework can provide. Where there is ongoing abuse or coercive control, safety should take priority over relational experimentation.